

One of the most famous naturalists in history, Charles Darwin had no academic training in zoology but was a passionate scientist at heart. On his voyage on HMS *Beagle*, he made careful records of numerous species, which gave him the ideas and the evidence for his theory of evolution by natural selection.

Charles Darwin was born in Shrewsbury, England, the son of a doctor. His mother, the daughter of the famous potter Josiah Wedgwood, died when Darwin was 8, and he was sent to boarding school. He went on to study medicine at Edinburgh University, but left because he found surgery too unpleasant. At his father's wish, he then went to Cambridge University in order to become a clergyman but, although he passed his exams, he spent much of his time studying natural history. In 1831, his friend John Henslow, professor of botany at Cambridge, offered him the chance to join HMS *Beagle* on an expedition that set out to survey the coastline of South America. The voyage lasted 5 years and was to change Darwin's life.

During the trip, Darwin devoted himself to collecting specimens, making detailed drawings, and reading. He was intrigued by the fantastic diversity of species he saw and started to think about how it had developed. He was especially captivated by the unusual wildlife of the Galápagos Islands. Noticing that some species on different islands—

“It is always advisable to **perceive** clearly **our ignorance.**”

Charles Darwin, 1872



Darwin saw marine iguanas and Galápagos finches, species unique to the Galápagos Islands. The highly specialized life forms found there inspired his initial discovery.

MILESTONES

VOYAGE OF A LIFETIME

Embarks from Plymouth on HMS *Beagle* in 1831. Arrives at the Galápagos Islands in 1835.

LOSS OF FAITH

His young daughter Annie dies in 1851, an event that undermines his already-faltering Christian faith.

SEMINAL PAPER

Produces his first paper on evolution, which is presented to the Linnean Society in 1858.

EVOLUTION THEORY

Publishes *On the Origin of Species* in 1859, causing a furor in a conservative society.

FINAL PUBLICATION

Claims that humans are descended from apes in his 1871 landmark book *The Descent of Man*.